wanted the bank to finance mobile phones for millions of poor Indian farmers, had the grace to call me the other day and say that the seeds of a digital India, powered by mobile telephony, were sown through the financing efforts undertaken by me and my team.

In 1997, I was transferred to Singapore to head the Corporate Advisory Function for the bank in Asia. Within a few months, the Asian financial crisis struck, crippling many of our bank's major customers. Covering countries as disparate as Thailand, Korea, Indonesia and Vietnam, our team helped to restructure and revive the fortunes of many major 'Asian tiger' companies. During my stay in Singapore, I took the opportunity to study Mandarin.

In 1999, I was assigned the task of drafting the acquisition bid for Bank of America's consumer banking operations in Asia. After the acquisition was finalized, I returned to oversee the integration of the two banks in India. The experience of banking operations and IT gained from my days at Grindlays Bank now proved to be very helpful. I jettisoned the old consumer banking platforms of both banks and, in collaboration with Infosys, implemented their new banking platform, Finacle. We were the first bank in the country to adopt the Finacle platform and helped Infosys customize it and introduce it in many parts of the world. This software is now the backbone of the Indian banking system.

During my travels to our branches across the world, I observed that we had lots of employees in expensive office spaces, doing routine bank processing activities. In 2001, I proposed to the Managing Board of ABN AMRO that by off-shoring these activities to India, we could save significant costs and increase profitability for the bank.

They gave the go-ahead, and I established the first office of a bank subsidiary that we called ACES, in an abandoned, derelict mill in the Lower Parel area of Mumbai. Our first employees were mostly children of the displaced mill workers, living in the chawls in the area. The excellent quality of their work gave the bank confidence to send more work to India. In the years that followed, I hired 15,000 people